

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

HOUSE BILL NO. 712

BY EDUCATION COMMITTEE

AN ACT

RELATING TO EDUCATION; AMENDING CHAPTER 5, TITLE 33, IDAHO CODE, BY THE ADDITION OF A NEW SECTION 33-528, IDAHO CODE, TO PROVIDE FOR THE IDAHO STATE SEAL OF EXCELLENCE IN CIVICS PROGRAM; AND DECLARING AN EMERGENCY AND PROVIDING AN EFFECTIVE DATE.

Be It Enacted by the Legislature of the State of Idaho:

SECTION 1. That Chapter 5, Title 33, Idaho Code, be, and the same is hereby amended by the addition thereto of a NEW SECTION, to be known and designated as Section 33-528, Idaho Code, and to read as follows:

33-528. IDAHO STATE SEAL OF EXCELLENCE IN CIVICS PROGRAM. (1) The legislature finds that a strong constitutional republic relies on citizens who possess civic knowledge, civic skills, civic values, and a commitment to constructive civic participation. It is the intent of the legislature to establish a voluntary diploma endorsement program recognizing Idaho students who have achieved excellence in civics education and civic engagement.

(2) There is hereby established the Idaho state seal of excellence in civics to recognize graduating high school students who have attained a high level of civics proficiency and civic engagement.

(3) Participation in the Idaho state seal of excellence in civics program is voluntary for school districts and public charter schools. A school district or public charter school shall notify the superintendent of public instruction of its intent to participate. Each participating school district or public charter school shall:

(a) Maintain records of students who meet program requirements;

(b) Identify each eligible student prior to graduation;

(c) Affix the state seal to each eligible student's diploma and note the award on the student's transcript; and

(d) Allow eligible students to wear a red, white, and blue honor cord during graduation ceremonies to recognize the achievement.

(4) To earn the Idaho state seal of excellence in civics, a student shall meet the following requirements:

(a) Demonstrate civic knowledge by:

(i) Successful completion of all state-required social studies coursework for graduation with an overall GPA of 3.25 or higher in such courses;

(ii) Demonstrating mastery, which shall be ninety percent (90%) or higher, on the Idaho civics assessment required by section 33-1602, Idaho Code; and

(iii) Completion of a civics inquiry or research project, which may include:

1. A civics readiness research project;

2. A capstone paper or presentation;

3. An advanced placement, international baccalaureate, or dual credit civics or government project; or
 4. A standards-aligned civics inquiry investigation;
- (b) Demonstrate civic participation by completing at least three (3) of the following:
- (i) Service learning or community service, requiring completion of at least fifty (50) hours of voluntary service with a public agency, school, nonprofit organization, or charitable organization that contributes to the public good. Students who enlist in the armed forces of the United States prior to graduation shall be deemed to have met this requirement;
 - (ii) Civic engagement activities, requiring participation in at least fifteen (15) hours of civic engagement activities, such as public meetings, mock trial, model united nations, American legion boys state or American legion auxiliary girls state, youth legislature, local government internship, or student government;
 - (iii) Completion of at least two (2) approved civic learning programs, including:
 1. Junior reserve officers' training corps, with a minimum two (2) year participation;
 2. Summer civics institutes;
 3. School-sponsored extracurricular civics programs; or
 4. Projects aligned to Idaho and United States government standards; or
 - (iv) Civics-related work experience, including internships, volunteering, and other work-based learning opportunities; and
- (c) Demonstrate good attendance and not incur any major disciplinary infractions, as defined by local school board policy.
- (5) The state seal shall be affixed to the diploma of a student who satisfies the requirements of this section and shall be noted on the student's official transcript. The state superintendent of public instruction shall design and produce the insignia and deliver appropriate quantities to participating school districts and public charter schools at no cost to students.
- (6) The state department of education shall provide participating school districts and public charter schools with implementation guidance surrounding participation in the state seal of excellence in civics program, including:
- (a) Rubrics, examples of eligible activities, and reporting templates;
 - (b) Professional development to support instruction aligned to civics proficiency; and
 - (c) Annually, a list of approved civic learning programs. Schools may design local projects, assessments, or activities that align with state civics standards.
- (7) Participating school districts and public charter schools shall report to the state department of education by August 1 each year:
- (a) The number of students awarded the Idaho state seal of excellence in civics; and
 - (b) Aggregate data on student participation in civic learning pathways.

1 (8) Any school that demonstrates that seventy-five percent (75%) or
2 more of its graduating senior students have earned the Idaho state seal of
3 excellence in civics shall be identified by the state department of educa-
4 tion as an Idaho school of civics excellence.

5 (9) The state department of education shall publish an annual statewide
6 summary for the Idaho legislature, governor, and communities regarding ex-
7 cellence in civics throughout the state.

8 SECTION 2. An emergency existing therefor, which emergency is hereby
9 declared to exist, this act shall be in full force and effect on and after
10 July 1, 2026.